

4 Ways to Stop Your Kid From Having Nightmares

1 Make daily processing time a routine.

Set up 30 minutes of talk time (preferably not right before bed, a time that should be reserved for happy discussions) with your child every day to allow them to express fears and thoughts on their nightmares, or anything else they might be worrying about. Kids have access to other children and technology when they're not at home, so it's important that parents take time each day to ask if there is anything they have seen or heard that is upsetting to them.

"When a child's fears are heard and explained in a calm and age-appropriate way, especially about grown-up things like current events, the child will be less likely to have nightmares related to those things," said Whitney Roban, Ph.D., a clinical psychologist, sleep specialist, and founder of Solve Our Sleep.



2 Turn nightmares into a "game."

Parents can make a "game" of nightmares by having the child choose their own ending. "Allow the child to make up a fun and positive ending to the nightmare, and they can write it down or draw a picture of how they want to see the nightmare end in a funny way in their own sleep journal," said Dr. Roban. Then, if the child happens to wake up from a nightmare, they can calm themselves down by thinking about — or looking at — the funny way they created the ending to the nightmare.



3 Use the right language.

It's often our knee jerk reaction as a parent to respond to our kids' fears by saying something like, "there's nothing to be scared of" or "it's okay, don't be scared." This doesn't help, though, and in fact it could make kids more upset, said Nilong Vyas, MD, board certified pediatrician & sleep consultant with Sleepless in NOLA. Instead, Dr. Vyas suggests saying something like "that does sound scary," or "oh, that would make me scared, too, but this is what I do when I get scared." Follow that up with an example of a coping mechanism, like taking deep breaths.



4 Prioritize a sleep routine.

Less sleep doesn't just equal a crankier kid: It could also be causing more nightmares. "Sleep deprivation is a major cause of nightmares," said Dr. Roban. That means having an early and consistent sleep schedule for your child is even more important than you may have originally thought. Try putting your child to bed at the same time every night with a relaxing bedtime routine. Avoid heavy meals or electronics before bed, and put them in a room environment that is dark, quiet, and cold.



♥ Watch for these signs, too:

Issues with nightmares may also exhibit in uncommon symptoms for some children. This could include things like:

- ♥ Sleep refusal or significant sleep deprivation
- ♥ School refusal or behavioral outbursts/inattention in school
- ♥ Social withdrawal or mental health issues, like anxiety and depression

If you see these signs start to pop up, start with your child's sleep routine. Although the occasional nightmare is common, when they cause significant emotional and/or behavioral changes to the child, it's time to seek professional help.

♥
Sweet
Dreams
♥

